

Dialect

WORD LIST

accent	articulate	dialect	diction	enunciate
hierarchy	intelligible	peer	stratify	stress

The many varieties of English make it a fascinating language. In England, people talk about the “bonnet,” not the “hood,” of a car; signs on apartments read “to let” rather than “for rent.” Scotland’s residents refer to a “wee” job rather than a “small” one. Even within the United States, we find many *dialects*, or language forms, that differ in pronunciation, vocabulary, and grammar.

- 1. accent** (ăk'sent) from Latin *ad-*, “to” + *cantus*, “song”
 - a. noun** A style of pronunciation typical of people from a certain region or country
 - Erin’s **accent** showed that she had been raised in Ireland.
 - b. noun** An emphasis on a particular syllable in a word
 - When saying the word *tidy*, we put the **accent** on the first syllable.
 - c. verb** To focus attention on
 - The color of that sweater really **accents** her blue eyes.
- 2. articulate** from Latin *articulare*, “say clearly”
 - a. adjective** (ăr-tîk'yă-lîl) Skilled in expressing oneself clearly and effectively
 - The senator was an **articulate** spokesperson for children’s rights.
 - b. verb** (ăr-tîk'yă-lăt) To express clearly in words
 - Feelings of love can be difficult to **articulate**.

articulation *noun* The worker’s convincing **articulation** of her accomplishments persuaded the boss to give her a raise.

- 3. dialect** (dî'ă-lĕkt) *noun* from Greek *dialectus*, “form of speech”
A unique form of a language, spoken by people from a country, region, or social group
 - In some **dialects** of English, the word *pop* is used to refer to *soda*.
- 4. diction** (dîk'shən) *noun* from Latin *dicee*, “to say”
Clearness of speech or pronunciation
 - An actor must have excellent **diction** to perform Shakespearean plays.
- 5. enunciate** (ĭ-nŭn'sĕ-ăt) *verb* from Latin *ex-*, “out” + *nuntiare*, “to announce”
 - a. To pronounce, especially in a clear manner**
 - The teacher **enunciated** the directions carefully so that students at the back of the large hall could hear her.
 - b. To state or set forth clearly**
 - In his speech, the president **enunciated** his foreign policy positions.

enunciation *noun* The lack of **enunciation** of lyrics can make some songs difficult to understand.

Definition b of the word *accent* can also be used as a verb: When saying the word *tidy*, we *accent* the first syllable.



Diction can also refer to one’s choice of words.

6. **hierarchy** (hī'ə-rār'kē) *noun* from Greek *hierarkhia*, "rule of high priest"

A group organized according to rank or status

- In the army **hierarchy**, a colonel ranks below a general.

hierarchical (hī'ə-rār'kī-kəl) *adjective* Many primates live in societies that are **hierarchical**, so some individuals are dominant and others are subordinate.

7. **intelligible** (īn-tēl'ī-jə-bəl) *adjective* from Latin *intellegerē*, "to perceive"

Able to be understood

- The two-year-old's speech was only **intelligible** to his parents.

intelligibility *noun* The **intelligibility** of the poem will be greatly increased if you know the myths to which it refers.

8. **peer** (pîr) *noun* from Latin *par*, "equal"

A person who is equal to another in social standing or age

- Teenagers tend to use the same expressions as their **peers**.

9. **stratify** (străt'ə-fī) *verb* from Latin *stratum*, "covering"

To separate into different levels or layers

- The bowling league was **stratified** into "A" players, with high averages, and "B" players, with lower ones.

stratification *noun* The **stratification** of the earth's rock layers reflects the climate, earthquakes, and volcanic activity over millions of years.

stratum *noun* (plural, **strata**) In the Middle Ages, nobles and peasants made up two separate **strata** of society.

10. **stress** (strēs) from Latin *stringere*, "to draw tight"

a. *noun* Emphasis in speaking or music

- The **stress** in the word "impossible" is placed on the second syllable.

b. *verb* To emphasize

- The nurse **stressed** the importance of a healthy diet.

c. *noun* Tension; strain

- Tests are a source of **stress** to many students.

The opposite of *intelligible* is *unintelligible*.

Peer has a homonym that means "to look intently."

Often, *stratify* means "to separate people into groups that differ in quality or in power."

WORD ENRICHMENT

What is "Standard English"?

English is rich in different dialects, but the pronunciation and grammar that we hear from most newscasters and that we read in most books is called "Standard English." This is the form used by most educated people, especially in the workplace and in more formal settings. Of course, Standard U.S. English is different from the standard form of English used in England.

WRITE THE CORRECT WORD

Write the correct word in the space next to each definition.

- | | |
|--|-----------------------------------|
| _____ 1. clearness of speech | _____ 6. to pronounce clearly |
| _____ 2. an equal in age or position | _____ 7. clear and expressive |
| _____ 3. pressure or strain | _____ 8. a style of pronunciation |
| _____ 4. a regional form of a language | _____ 9. to separate into layers |
| _____ 5. a group organized by rank | _____ 10. understandable |

COMPLETE THE SENTENCE

Write the letter for the word that best completes each sentence.

- _____ 1. The club president _____ the club's reasons for wanting to raise money.
a. accented b. stratified c. articulated d. enunciated
- _____ 2. My league is _____ into teams for new golfers and for experienced ones.
a. stressed b. stratified c. accented d. articulated
- _____ 3. Most businesses are organized into a(n) _____, with positions ranging from entry level jobs to the CEO of the company.
a. diction b. accent c. articulation d. hierarchy
- _____ 4. Large countries often include regions where people speak different _____ of the country's main language.
a. dictions b. stratifications c. dialects d. peers
- _____ 5. The speaker's _____ revealed that she probably had grown up in England.
a. accent b. stratification c. hierarchy d. intelligibility
- _____ 6. When dictating the spelling test, the teacher carefully _____ each word.
a. enunciated b. stressed c. stratified d. accented
- _____ 7. The message on the answering machine was so garbled that it was barely _____.
a. stressed b. hierarchical c. accented d. intelligible
- _____ 8. Do you think that choices of clothing are influenced by one's _____?
a. stresses b. peers c. dialects d. accents
- _____ 9. It's hard to have good _____ when you talk with food in your mouth.
a. hierarchy b. stratification c. dialect d. diction
- _____ 10. Many people experience great nervousness and _____ when speaking in public.
a. stratification b. diction c. stress d. articulation

Challenge: The _____ of the student club into a many-leveled _____ disappointed some members who had articulated their opposition to the plan.
a. stress...stratification b. stratification...hierarchy c. enunciation...dialect

Dialects from Coast to Coast

Suppose that, while watching the news one evening, you see a report of a flood in another region of the United States. The reporter is interviewing a resident of the area. English subtitles appear on your television screen, so you assume the speaker is using another language. Then, you realize—that person is speaking English!

- (1) People who live in different regions of a country often speak different *dialects*. (2) Some are so distinct that subtitles—or an interpreter—are needed to help make them *intelligible* to people from other regions. (3) This is particularly true when the speaker's *diction* is not very good.

Dialects often have a unique vocabulary, as well. A *hero* sandwich in Philadelphia is a *po'boy* in New Orleans. A *potluck* supper in Tennessee might be called a *pitch-in* in Indiana, and a *scramble* in Illinois. (4) If one of your *peers* wanted to play *potsy*, she'd probably be from Manhattan; if he wanted to play *sky blue*, he might be a Chicago boy. Both would be asking you to play a game known in other areas as *hopscotch*!

(5) Sometimes, vowels are *articulated* in different ways in different dialects. Let's use the word *coffee*, for example. In Seattle, one drinks "cahfee," and in New York City, one drinks "cawfee." (6) In Los Angeles, you might be directed to "take a right," but someone with an Atlanta accent would tell you to "tick a raht."

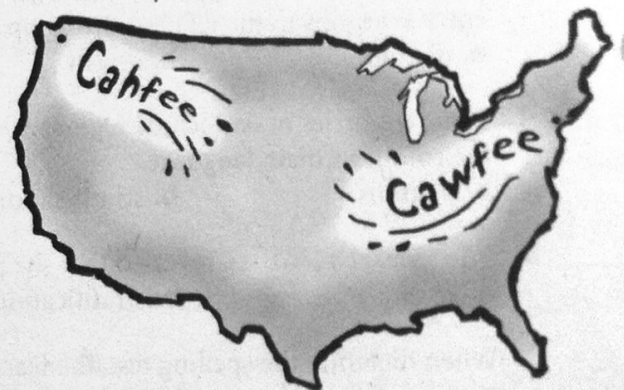
(7) The *enunciation* of consonants and syllables also varies from one region to another. A Denver native might visit a relative who lives by the Chesapeake Bay in Baltimore; but that relative would say that she lives by the "Chestpeak" Bay in "Baltmer." In Phoenix, you might be instructed to "park your car in the parking lot"; in

Boston, you would probably be told to "pahk yuh cah in the pahking lot."

(8) The *stress* of a word may differ from region to region, as well. A Miami native would use an um-BREL-la in the rain; a person from Cincinnati would use an UM-brell-a.

Dictionaries tend to focus on Standard English usage rather than dialect differences. But *The Dictionary of American Regional English*, or *DARE* for short, references phrases and pronunciations that differ from region to region. The dictionary notes where each term is used and how words are pronounced in different places. (9) The experts who put together the first four volumes of *DARE* spent years interviewing people from all over the country and from different *strata* of society.

(10) Some language experts propose a *hierarchy* of dialects, arguing for a preferred standard version of English. On the other hand, the writers of *DARE* strive to document all variations of English spoken in the United States. They want to create a record of the richness and cultural diversity of American society.



Each sentence below refers to a numbered sentence in the passage. Write the letter of the choice that gives the sentence a meaning that is closest to the original sentence.

- _____ 1. People who live in different regions of a country often speak different _____.
a. traditions b. styles of pronunciation c. local customs d. forms of language
- _____ 2. Some are so distinct that subtitles—or an interpreter—are needed to help make them _____ to people from other regions.
a. understandable b. acceptable c. appealing d. emphasized
- _____ 3. This is particularly true when the speaker's _____ is not very good.
a. appearance b. use of props c. clearness of speech d. skill
- _____ 4. If one of your _____ wanted to play *potsy*, she'd probably be from Manhattan.
a. two parents b. friends your age c. ranked groups d. distant relatives

5. Sometimes, vowels are _____ in different ways in different dialects.
a. arranged b. pronounced c. layered d. dictated
6. In Los Angeles, you might be directed to "take a right," but someone with an Atlanta _____ would tell you to "tick a raht."
a. form of language b. spelling c. emphasis d. style of pronunciation
7. The _____ of consonants and syllables also varies from one region to another.
a. pronunciation b. spelling c. punctuation d. hearing
8. The _____ of a word may differ from region to region, as well.
a. written version b. dictation c. vowel sounds d. syllable emphasis
9. The experts spent years interviewing people from all over the country and from different _____ of society.
a. levels b. regions c. age groups d. geographies
10. Some language experts propose a(n) _____ of dialects, arguing for a preferred standard version of English.
a. emphasis b. ranking c. clarity d. collection

Indicate whether the statements below are TRUE or FALSE according to the passage.

1. People in different areas of the United States sometimes stress different syllables in the same word.
2. Dialect differences may include both different pronunciations of the same words and different words representing the same object.
3. The writers of *DARE* believe that some dialects are better than others.

WRITING EXTENDED RESPONSES

As the passage indicates, some people believe that dialect differences are good, and some think that it would be better if we all spoke the same dialect. Consider which of these two positions you agree with. Then write a persuasive essay detailing your point of view. Your essay should contain at least two reasons for your position and should be a minimum of three paragraphs long. If you choose, instead of taking one point of view, you may present arguments from both sides. Use at least three lesson words in your essay and underline them.

WRITE THE DERIVATIVE

Complete the sentence by writing the correct form of the word shown in parentheses. You may not need to change the form that is given.

1. The teacher told Jeremy that the _____ of his oral report would improve if he spoke more slowly and clearly. (*intelligible*)
2. The accused person was tried by a jury of his _____. (*peer*)

- _____ 3. The substitute teacher's unfamiliar _____ was confusing to the students. (*dialect*)
- _____ 4. The actor's _____ was so clear that even those in the back row of the auditorium could hear his every word. (*diction*)
- _____ 5. Earthquakes are one cause of visible _____ in the earth's surface. (*stratify*)
- _____ 6. Many large organizations have complicated _____. (*hierarchy*)
- _____ 7. The English teacher _____ each syllable very deliberately. (*enunciate*)
- _____ 8. Each time he plays that song, the drummer _____ the first and third beats of every measure. (*accent*)
- _____ 9. Before every game last year, the coach _____ the game plan in detail. (*articulate*)
- _____ 10. My former math teacher always _____ the importance of doing orderly work when solving problems. (*stress*)

FIND THE EXAMPLE

Choose the answer that best describes the action or situation.

- _____ 1. Something arranged in a *hierarchy*
a. the military b. fruit c. a mall d. a book
- _____ 2. A performer who would most likely use regional *dialects*
a. a pianist b. a storyteller c. a pantomimist d. a ballerina
- _____ 3. A common source of *stress*
a. resting b. sleeping c. eating d. competing
- _____ 4. Something you would *accent*
a. a sentence b. a syllable c. a paragraph d. a letter
- _____ 5. Someone who needs to be *articulate*
a. a politician b. a wrestler c. a painter d. a runner
- _____ 6. Something that should NOT be *intelligible* to everyone
a. a phone message b. a public order c. a secret code d. your handwriting
- _____ 7. Someone who would be your ultimate *peer*
a. a friend b. a parent c. a twin d. a child
- _____ 8. A place where you would be most likely to observe *strata*
a. a rough ocean b. a rock cliff c. a parking lot d. a field of flowers
- _____ 9. A performer who needs to have good *diction*
a. a tap dancer b. a stage actor c. an acrobat d. a violinist
- _____ 10. An event at which one should *enunciate* very clearly
a. a sports event b. a rock concert c. a county fair d. a spelling bee